

Unit I :: Frames of Reference

 **PHY01MX01R04: Mechanics and Properties of Matter** 

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Syllabus

Unit I: Frames of Reference

Review of Newton's laws of motion; inertial frames of reference, Galilean transformations, Galilean invariance; non-inertial frames of reference, fictitious (inertial) forces – centrifugal force, Coriolis force; transformation equations in inclined and rotating frames.

1 Review of Newton's laws of motion

Before delving into a review of Newton's laws of motion, we need to be clear of the definitions of some important terms used in mechanics:

- *Particle*: an idealized object that has mass and position but occupies zero volume.
- *Event*: a specific occurrence that happens at a unique place in space and a specific instant in time.
- *Observer*: a person or an equipment which can locate, record, measure and interpret an event.
- *Frame of reference*: a coordinate system combined with a clock, used by an observer to measure the position and motion of particles.
- *Rest*: a particle is said to be at rest when its position does not change relative to a chosen frame of reference over time.
- *Motion*: the change in position or orientation of an object with respect to a chosen frame of reference over time.
- *Inertia*: the tendency of a body to resist any change in its motion or configuration.
- *Position*: the location of a particle in space with respect to a fixed reference point known as the origin. If (x, y, z) are the coordinates of a particle in Cartesian space, then its position vector is

$$\mathbf{r} = x\hat{\mathbf{i}} + y\hat{\mathbf{j}} + z\hat{\mathbf{k}} \quad (1)$$

- *Displacement*: the change in the position of a particle. If a particle is initially at the position $\mathbf{r}_i = x_i\hat{\mathbf{i}} + y_i\hat{\mathbf{j}} + z_i\hat{\mathbf{k}}$ and then finally moves to the position $\mathbf{r}_f = x_f\hat{\mathbf{i}} + y_f\hat{\mathbf{j}} + z_f\hat{\mathbf{k}}$, its displacement vector is

$$\Delta\mathbf{r} = \mathbf{r}_f - \mathbf{r}_i = (x_f - x_i)\hat{\mathbf{i}} + (y_f - y_i)\hat{\mathbf{j}} + (z_f - z_i)\hat{\mathbf{k}} \quad (2)$$

If the displacement is infinitesimally small, then we can write

$$d\mathbf{r} = \hat{\mathbf{i}}dx + \hat{\mathbf{j}}dy + \hat{\mathbf{k}}dz \quad (3)$$

- *Velocity*: the rate of change of position of a particle. If the position of a particle varies with time, then its instantaneous velocity is the first derivative of its position with respect to time.

$$\mathbf{v} = \dot{\mathbf{r}} = \frac{d\mathbf{r}}{dt} \quad (4)$$

If the positions of a particle at two instants of time are $\mathbf{r}(t_1) = \mathbf{r}_1$ and $\mathbf{r}(t_2) = \mathbf{r}_2$, then its displacement is obtained by the integral

$$\begin{aligned} \int_{\mathbf{r}_1}^{\mathbf{r}_2} d\mathbf{r} &= \int_{t_1}^{t_2} \mathbf{v} dt \\ \Rightarrow \mathbf{r}_2 - \mathbf{r}_1 &= \int_{t_1}^{t_2} \mathbf{v} dt \end{aligned} \quad (5)$$

- *Acceleration*: the rate of change of velocity of a particle. If the velocity of a particle varies with time, then its instantaneous acceleration is the first derivative of its velocity with respect to time, or the second derivative of its position with respect to time.

$$\mathbf{a} = \dot{\mathbf{v}} = \frac{d\mathbf{v}}{dt} \quad (6)$$

$$\text{or } \mathbf{a} = \ddot{\mathbf{r}} = \frac{d^2\mathbf{r}}{dt^2} \quad (7)$$

If the velocities of a particle at two instants of time are $\mathbf{v}(t_1) = \mathbf{v}_1$ and $\mathbf{v}(t_2) = \mathbf{v}_2$, then the change in its velocity is obtained by the integral

$$\begin{aligned} \int_{\mathbf{v}_1}^{\mathbf{v}_2} d\mathbf{v} &= \int_{t_1}^{t_2} \mathbf{a} dt \\ \Rightarrow \mathbf{v}_2 - \mathbf{v}_1 &= \int_{t_1}^{t_2} \mathbf{a} dt \end{aligned} \quad (8)$$

- *Momentum*: the product of the mass and velocity of a body, i.e. $\mathbf{p} = m\mathbf{v}$. In mechanics, we also refer to the momentum of a body as its *amount of motion*.

1.1 Kinematics relations

The kinematic relations are a set of formulae in mechanics that describe the motion of objects moving with constant acceleration, without considering the forces that cause the motion.

1.1.1 Velocity-time relation

Consider the motion of a particle moving with a constant acceleration $\mathbf{a}$. Let its initial velocity be $\mathbf{v}_1 = \mathbf{v}_0$ at time $t_1 = 0$, and its final velocity be $\mathbf{v}_2 = \mathbf{v}(t)$ at some arbitrary time t . Then from equation (8), we have

$$\begin{aligned} \mathbf{v}(t) - \mathbf{v}_0 &= \mathbf{a} \int_0^t dt \\ \Rightarrow \mathbf{v}(t) - \mathbf{v}_0 &= \mathbf{a}(t - 0) \\ \Rightarrow \boxed{\mathbf{v}(t) = \mathbf{v}_0 + \mathbf{a}t} \end{aligned} \quad (9)$$

which is the *velocity-time relation*, or the *first kinematic relation*.

1.1.2 Position-time relation

Consider the motion of a particle moving with a constant acceleration $\mathbf{a}$. Let its initial position be $\mathbf{r}_1 = \mathbf{r}_0$ at time $t_1 = 0$, and its final position be $\mathbf{r}_2 = \mathbf{r}(t)$ at some arbitrary time t . Then from

equation (5), we have

$$\begin{aligned}
 \mathbf{r}(t) - \mathbf{r}_0 &= \int_0^t \mathbf{v} dt \\
 &= \int_0^t (\mathbf{v}_0 + \mathbf{a}t) dt \quad [\text{using eqn. (9)}] \\
 &= \mathbf{v}_0 \int_0^t dt + \mathbf{a} \int_0^t t dt \\
 &= \mathbf{v}_0(t - 0) + \mathbf{a} \frac{t^2}{2} \Big|_0^t \\
 \Rightarrow \boxed{\mathbf{r}(t) = \mathbf{r}_0 + \mathbf{v}_0 t + \frac{1}{2} \mathbf{a} t^2} & \quad (10)
 \end{aligned}$$

which is the *position-time relation*, or the *second kinematic relation*.

1.1.3 Position-velocity relation

We know that

$$\mathbf{a} = \frac{d\mathbf{v}}{dt}$$

Taking the dot product of the above with an infinitesimal displacement $d\mathbf{r}$, we have

$$\begin{aligned}
 \mathbf{a} \cdot d\mathbf{r} &= \frac{d\mathbf{v}}{dt} \cdot d\mathbf{r} \\
 \Rightarrow \mathbf{a} \cdot d\mathbf{r} &= \frac{d\mathbf{r}}{dt} \cdot d\mathbf{v} \\
 \Rightarrow \mathbf{a} \cdot d\mathbf{r} &= \mathbf{v} \cdot d\mathbf{v} \quad (11)
 \end{aligned}$$

Now, using the product rule for differentiation, we have

$$\begin{aligned}
 d(\mathbf{v} \cdot \mathbf{v}) &= d\mathbf{v} \cdot \mathbf{v} + \mathbf{v} \cdot d\mathbf{v} \\
 \Rightarrow 2\mathbf{v} \cdot d\mathbf{v} &= d(\mathbf{v} \cdot \mathbf{v}) \\
 \Rightarrow \mathbf{v} \cdot d\mathbf{v} &= \frac{1}{2} d(\mathbf{v} \cdot \mathbf{v})
 \end{aligned}$$

Then equation (11) becomes

$$\mathbf{a} \cdot d\mathbf{r} = \frac{1}{2} d(\mathbf{v} \cdot \mathbf{v}) \quad (12)$$

Suppose we have a particle moving under constant acceleration $\mathbf{a}$. If at its initial and final positions $\mathbf{r}_0$ and $\mathbf{r}$, it has initial and final velocities $\mathbf{v}_0$ and $\mathbf{v}$, then we can integrate equation (eqn:adr-

v dv-02) as

$$\begin{aligned}
 \mathbf{a} \cdot \int_{\mathbf{r}_0}^{\mathbf{r}} d\mathbf{r} &= \frac{1}{2} \int_{\mathbf{v}_0}^{\mathbf{v}} d(\mathbf{v} \cdot \mathbf{v}) \\
 \Rightarrow \mathbf{a} \cdot \mathbf{r} \Big|_{\mathbf{r}_0}^{\mathbf{r}} &= \frac{1}{2} \mathbf{v} \cdot \mathbf{v} \Big|_{\mathbf{v}_0}^{\mathbf{v}} \\
 \Rightarrow \mathbf{a} \cdot (\mathbf{r} - \mathbf{r}_0) &= \frac{1}{2} (\mathbf{v} \cdot \mathbf{v} - \mathbf{v}_0 \cdot \mathbf{v}_0) \\
 &= \frac{1}{2} (v^2 - v_0^2) \\
 \Rightarrow \boxed{v^2} &= v_0^2 + 2\mathbf{a} \cdot (\mathbf{r} - \mathbf{r}_0) \quad (13)
 \end{aligned}$$

which is the *position-velocity relation*, or the *third kinematic relation*.

1.2 Newton's laws of motion

1.2.1 Newton's first law of motion

A particle tends to maintain its state of rest or uniform motion unless it is acted upon by an external agency.

- The importance of Newton's first law of motion lies in that it defines force as:

Force is any external agency that brings about a change in the state of rest or uniform motion of a particle.

1.2.2 Newton's second law of motion

The rate of change of momentum of a particle is directly proportional to the force exerted on it, and takes place in the direction of the force.

$$\mathbf{F} \propto \frac{d\mathbf{p}}{dt}$$

This implies that we have

$$\mathbf{F} = k \frac{d\mathbf{p}}{dt}$$

where k is the proportionality constant.

Now, for a particle of mass m and moving with a velocity $\mathbf{v}$, its momentum is defined as $\mathbf{p} = m\mathbf{v}$. Hence, Newton's second law becomes

$$\begin{aligned}
 \mathbf{F} &= k \frac{d}{dt}(m\mathbf{v}) \\
 &= km \frac{d\mathbf{v}}{dt} \quad [\text{assuming } m \text{ to be constant}] \\
 \mathbf{F} &= k m \mathbf{a}
 \end{aligned}$$

The constant k is set to 1 by our choice of the units of force. We define 1 newton to be that amount of force that brings about an acceleration of 1 m/s^2 on a particle of mass 1 kg. Then from the above, we have

$$(1 \text{ N}) = k \times (1 \text{ kg}) \times (1 \text{ m/s}^2) \\ \Rightarrow k = 1$$

Therefore, for a particle *whose mass remains unchanged*, Newton's second law of motion can be written as

$$\boxed{\mathbf{F} = m\mathbf{a}}$$

- The importance of Newton's second law of motion lies in that it measures force as:

If a force of magnitude F brings about an acceleration a on a particle of mass m , then the force is measured to be $F = ma$.

1.2.3 Newton's third law of motion

For every action, there is an equal and opposite reaction, both of which act on different bodies.

$$\mathbf{F}_{12} = -\mathbf{F}_{21}$$

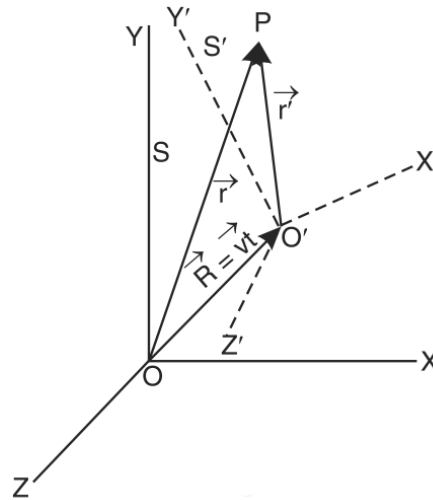
- The importance of Newton's second law of motion lies in that it gives the origin of force as:

If a particle experiences a force of magnitude F , it is because it exerts another force of the same magnitude F but in the opposite direction on some other particle.

2 Inertial frames of reference

A reference frame (e.g. a coordinate system) in which Newton's first law of motion holds good, is known as an *inertial frame of reference*. Hence, in an inertial frame a body continues in its state of rest or of uniform motion as long as no external force acts on it.

All frames of reference moving with a constant velocity with respect to an inertial frame are also inertial frames of reference.



Consider an inertial frame of reference S and another reference frame S' , such that their orientations in space remain fixed and are thus free to have only translatory motion with respect to one another. Suppose further that the origins O and O' at the two systems initially coincident.

As shown in the figure the frame S' has moved into its current position in time t with a constant velocity $\mathbf{v}$ relative to S . Then we have

$$\vec{OO'} = \mathbf{R} = \mathbf{v}t$$

The position vectors $\mathbf{r}$ and $\mathbf{r}'$ of a particle P , with respect to the two frames of reference are then related as

$$\begin{aligned}\mathbf{r} &= \mathbf{R} + \mathbf{r}' \\ \Rightarrow \mathbf{r}' &= \mathbf{r} - \mathbf{R} \\ \Rightarrow \mathbf{r}' &= \mathbf{r} - \mathbf{v}t\end{aligned}$$

Differentiating the above, we get

$$\frac{d\mathbf{r}'}{dt} = \frac{d\mathbf{r}}{dt} - \mathbf{v}$$

Differentiating once again, we get

$$\begin{aligned}\frac{d^2\mathbf{r}'}{dt^2} &= \frac{d^2\mathbf{r}}{dt^2} \\ \Rightarrow \mathbf{a}' &= \mathbf{a}\end{aligned}$$

Hence, the acceleration of the particle is the same in the two frames of reference. This indicates that if the particle is at rest or uniform motion in the frame S , then it would also appear to be at rest or uniform motion in the other frame S' .

Therefore, all frames of reference, moving with a constant velocity with respect to an inertial frame, are also inertial frames of reference.

Examples of inertial frames of reference:

1. An object in deep space, away from any gravitational influence, can be considered to be in an inertial frame of reference.
2. An object falling freely under the influence of gravity can be considered to be in an inertial frame of reference.